

Can You Discern the Principle Behind the Law?

2026 Regional Convention — Talk No. 13

Manuscript draft | Assigned time: 24 minutes | Two videos

Green = main idea · Orange = contrast · Blue = application or delivery action

WHAT IS THE DIFFERENCE BETWEEN A LAW AND A PRINCIPLE? (3 min.)

(Friendly, inviting)

If a law tells us what we must or must not do, what does a principle do? And why does discerning the principle matter to a mature Christian? The following video gives us a simple picture. As you watch, notice what remains after a particular rule no longer applies.

VIDEO 1 — Play 08-CO-v26_E_131 (outline: 2:04; file runtime: 2:05)

A law may state a specific requirement. A principle is a timeless truth behind that law; it helps us understand Jehovah's thinking. A young child may obey mainly to avoid displeasing a parent. As love and understanding grow, the child sees the reason and wants to share the parent's values. Psalm 119:104 links understanding with rejecting a wrong course. **Knowing and loving the Person behind the command makes heartfelt obedience easier.**

“YOU HEARD THAT IT WAS SAID . . . HOWEVER, I SAY TO YOU” (18 min.)

In the Sermon on the Mount, Jesus repeatedly said: “You heard that it was said . . . However, I say to you.” He was not criticising the Mosaic Law. Matthew 5:17-48 shows that he revealed the fundamental truths behind its commands. The written Law covenant was taken out of the way, as Colossians 2:13, 14 explains, but its righteous principles did not change. Why not? Because, as Malachi 3:6 reminds us, Jehovah does not change.

Let us consider the six examples Jesus used. With each one, ask: **What does this teach me about Jehovah, and how should it shape my choices?**

1. Murder — Make peace quickly

At Matthew 5:21-26, Jesus moved beneath the command, “You must not murder,” to the anger and contempt from which violence can grow. A person might say, “I have never murdered anyone,” while nursing hatred, humiliating a brother, or refusing every effort at peace. Jesus showed that Jehovah, the God of peace, cares about what is developing in the heart, not only the final act.

The principle is clear: Jehovah holds us accountable for hatred, where murder begins. So Jesus urged his listener to settle matters quickly. If I know that a brother has something against me, love does not ask, “Am I technically guilty?” It asks, “What can I do to restore peace?” We take the initiative, speak privately and calmly, listen, apologise where needed, and do not allow anger to become a permanent resident.

Jesus even placed reconciliation ahead of completing a gift at the altar. That shows how seriously Jehovah views peace between his worshippers. We cannot compensate for refusing to address a damaged relationship by being visibly busy in sacred service. Of course, peace requires two willing people, and we cannot control another’s response. But we can promptly do our part with humility and leave no fuel for hatred in our own heart.

2. Adultery — Protect holiness and loyal love

Next, at Matthew 5:27-30, Jesus looked behind the command against adultery. He showed that a passionate, disloyal looking can cultivate adultery in the heart. Jehovah is holy, and the marriage bond reflects loyal love. So sexual unfaithfulness does not begin only with physical contact. It may begin when someone deliberately feeds desire for a person who is not his or her mate.

What is the application? Jesus’ strong language about removing an eye or a hand calls for decisive measures, not literal injury. Reject pornography and anything that trains the eyes to be disloyal. Do not bargain with a source of temptation. At the same time, cultivate contentment and affection for your own mate. The aim is more than avoiding a prohibited act; it is protecting a holy bond and learning to love loyally as Jehovah does.

That may require changing a private routine, ending inappropriate contact, moving a device, or asking for help before a pattern becomes entrenched. Such action is not an overreaction when something precious is at risk. A person who loves

Jehovah's holiness does not ask how close he can get to wrongdoing. He asks how fully he can protect his heart, his mate, and his friendship with Jehovah.

3. Divorce — Do not let selfishness endanger others

Matthew 5:31, 32 addresses divorce. Under the Mosaic Law, a certificate of divorce provided a formal process and gave a measure of protection to the wife. But selfish men could misuse divorce and expose others to serious moral and emotional harm. Jesus restored respect for Jehovah's original standard for marriage.

The principle warns us that **a selfish choice may place both us and others in danger of serious sin.** So when a marriage is difficult, a Christian does not quickly give up or look for an easier attachment. We seek help, work at communication, forgive, and imitate Jehovah's loyal love. Endurance is not passive neglect; it includes making changes that help the entire family grow spiritually. The goal is not merely to keep a legal arrangement intact but to honour the Person who created marriage.

Jehovah notices the pain that marital disloyalty creates; he does not view it as a private shortcut to happiness. A loyal course considers the mate's dignity, the children's security, and everyone's spiritual welfare. It may take patience and repeated effort to rebuild warmth. But when both mates keep applying Bible counsel, they give Jehovah's loyal love room to shape the atmosphere of the home.

4. Oaths — Let your "Yes" mean yes

At Matthew 5:33-37, Jesus discussed oaths. The issue was not that every oath was wrong. Rather, people could use impressive promises to disguise unreliability. An impossible promise can be immodest; a promise never intended to be kept is dishonest. Jehovah is "the God of truth," so his worshippers should not need elaborate wording to make ordinary statements believable.

The principle is: **Love for the God of truth makes us truthful and dependable.** Before making a commitment, think realistically. Once we give our word, do what we said—even when it becomes inconvenient. Our simple "Yes" should carry weight at home, in the congregation, at work, and in financial matters. Integrity is not produced by the size of the promise but by the consistency with which we keep it.

This includes small commitments: arriving when we said we would, completing a task, returning what we borrowed, and correcting an impression when our words were misunderstood in our favour. We do not divide speech into occasions when precision matters and occasions when it does not. The more our everyday words reflect Jehovah's truthfulness, the less we need verbal guarantees to persuade people to trust us.

5. "Eye for eye" — Trust Jehovah's justice

Jesus next referred to "eye for eye and tooth for tooth" at Matthew 5:38-42. That law was given to judges to ensure measured justice; it was not permission for personal revenge. Yet an offended person could use the wording to justify retaliation. Jesus taught his disciples not to answer every injury by insisting on personal repayment.

The principle is: Jehovah values true, proportionate justice, and he—not wounded pride—is the final Judge. First Peter 2:23 says that when Jesus suffered, he did not threaten but entrusted himself to the One who judges righteously. We imitate him when we refuse to retaliate and leave justice with Jehovah.

That does not mean that a Christian can never seek proper protection or use an appropriate arrangement to address serious wrong. The point is the spirit in which we act. Are we seeking safety and what is right, or are we trying to make another person hurt because we hurt? Trust in Jehovah keeps justice from being hijacked by resentment.

The next video shows that this involves more than technically avoiding revenge. Watch how a brother moves from thinking about what is merely required to discerning what love would do.

VIDEO 2 — Play 10-CO-v26_E_132 (outline: 6:29; file runtime: 6:21)

What changed? The brother had been treated unfairly and lost an opportunity. At first, "turn the other cheek" seemed to mean giving the minimum cooperation and no open retaliation. But meditation helped him see the deeper principle: love moved him to go the extra mile and help the colleague who received the assignment. He prayed, offered his notes and assistance, and entrusted the outcome to Jehovah. He did not merely suppress revenge; he replaced it with goodness. That protected his peace, helped another person, and ultimately strengthened his family's happiness.

Notice that prayer did not make the unfairness imaginary, and the loving course was not effortless. It helped him decide whose thinking would govern his response. By acting generously while the disappointment was still real, he proved that principle-based love is stronger than wounded pride. He also prevented one workplace decision from controlling the spiritual priorities of his whole family.

6. Love your enemies — Imitate your Father

Finally, Matthew 5:43-48 mentions the saying, “You must love your neighbour and hate your enemy.” The command to love one’s neighbour came from the Hebrew Scriptures; the instruction to hate an enemy did not. Jesus pointed instead to his Father, who gives sunlight and rain even to people who oppose him.

Here the deepest principle is unmistakable: **Jehovah is love, and loving even opposers means imitating him.** First John 4:8, 19 explains that we love because he first loved us. So we do not limit goodness to people who agree with us or can repay us. We avoid partiality, speak respectfully, and look for opportunities to be kind. Love does not approve wrong conduct, but it refuses to let another person’s hostility dictate our character.

This principle has special force in our ministry. Some people may dismiss the message, misjudge our motives, or speak unkindly. We still see a person for whom Jehovah has shown patience. We do not label an entire household by one difficult response. Like the Father who keeps giving sun and rain, we remain impartial and leave open the possibility that kindness now may make truth easier to hear later.

All six examples lead to one conclusion. Romans 13:8-10 says that love fulfils the Law because love does no harm to one’s neighbour. Christian commands, including Jesus’ direction at Matthew 28:19 to make disciples, reflect Jehovah’s love. We obey them best when we discern not only what Jehovah asks, but why he asks it.

LOVE THE PERSON BEHIND THE PRINCIPLE (3 min.)

No one knows the Father better than Jesus. At Matthew 11:27, Jesus said that he knows the Father intimately and reveals Him to others. That is what Jesus was doing in the Sermon on the Mount. He was not merely raising the difficulty level of six laws. He was helping us see Jehovah’s personality within them.

The same is true of the “law of the Christ” mentioned at Galatians 6:2. Its commands and principles reveal a loving Lawgiver. **A principle shows the**

reason for a law, and that reason opens a window into Jehovah's thinking.

Return to the crossing-road illustration in the first video. When the child grows, he does not stand at the kerb waiting for his mother to arrive and hold his hand. The specific childhood rule is no longer needed. But respect for life and appreciation for loving guidance should remain. In the same way, Christian maturity is not independence from Jehovah. It is the ability to carry his thinking into situations where no detailed rule tells us every step.

So when facing a decision, pray for discernment. Search for the principle. Ask: "What does this reveal about Jehovah? Which choice would imitate him?" Proverbs 2:4, 9 encourages us to keep searching for wisdom; then we can understand the entire course of what is good.

The more clearly we see Jehovah's reasons, the more deeply we love him. And the more we love him, the less obedience feels like staying just inside a boundary. We want what he wants. Discern the principle, imitate the Person behind it, and enjoy the lasting happiness that comes from thinking like Jehovah.